



UID gets funding

A high powered cabinet committee recently sanctioned Rs. 3,023 crores to the Unique Identification Authority for the implementation of the second phase of the project



Remote locate

Volvo India recently launched the CareTrack navigation system which will allow remote monitoring of construction equipment

Cover feature

3 Do you understand the words that are coming out of my mouth?

Like in the movie Rush Hour, we Indians waste a lot of time trying to understand each other. From frustrating experiences when talking to customers or companies, to trying to explain to the cab driver, in a city you're visiting, where you want to go. Although most of us city and town dwellers will have it easier, we can't even fathom the thought of villagers from a northern state trying to communicate with those from a southern or eastern state. Besides, not all of India is comfortable in either English or Hindi, and with so many languages and dialects spoken across India, the only real way to get India as a whole to move forward is to make people understand each other.

Solution: Babel-babble

A mobile-based real-time, two-way translator, that converts a spoken language to any other language. So basically, all you'd need to do is hold your mobile (or another mobile translation device) near someone who's speaking a language you cannot understand, and it translates and speaks to you telling you what he or she said. Then when you want to reply, you speak into the device, and it translates what you said into the person's language. Let's call it Babel-babble. Of course, the Bb (Babel-babble, not RIM's BB) would also be a cool phone with gesture controls and a holographic display thrown in for good measure, and not just a translation device – just in case you needed a little extra incentive to carry one around!

How it could work

Although we'd like nothing better than the Babel fish from The Hitchhiker's Guide to the Galaxy, the Babel-babble would be the next best thing. With a headphone jack as well as a speaker, so that you could listen to translations privately, and also allow the person in front of you to hear what you're trying to tell them, the Bb will be our new best friend.

Challenges here are rather huge. For example, the kind of translation we're

expecting, in real-time, would mean our little mobile device would need a dual Core i7 setup, at least. Not exactly the computing power you expect from mobiles. Also, the size of database that would be needed, to translate from any language to another would be humongous, and not exactly something we could fit on a mobile device. But would we need to?

The ordinary

Text: Google has a very decent translation engine for text, and though grammar is not always correct, that's immaterial as the point gets across. Google's service is a lot better than you could do trying to stutter your way through German or Japanese. But what about the difference between Bengali and Assamese, or Tamil and Malayalam? That's where we come in. Although we're sure Google loves India, and is very involved in this, nothing stops us from doing the same.

Phraselator: Developed by Voxtec (voxtec.com) for the US army, the Phraselator calls itself the "ultimate mobile translation system". What it does is basically read out pre-defined phrases in whatever output language you select. It's also customisable, so you can add your own phrases to it, provided you know someone to tell you the equivalent translation in the other languages. Why do we get the funny feeling that

someone somewhere has reprogrammed a buddy's Phraselator to only spew out abuses? Adding insult to injury in war-torn countries?

The extraordinary

Google again: Their translations lab is said to be working on a speech-to-speech translation for the Android platform. In an interview with The Times (UK) earlier this year, Google's head of all things translation, Franz Och said he was confident of speech-to-speech technology working reasonably well within just a few years. He said, "Clearly, for it to work smoothly, you need a combination of high-accuracy machine translation and high-accuracy voice recognition, and that's what we're working on."

The biggest challenge with speech-to-speech, as expected, is natural language parsing. This has been the bane of speech recognition technology for ages now.

With thousands of languages, and hundreds of distinct accents for most languages, it's no surprise that our always precise PCs have trouble understanding those imperfect, stupid beings called humans. Still, we've seen software solutions that work better after a time, learning from their mistakes, after you "train" them.

This could work well if two people with early prototype versions of the Babel-babble were to talk to each other. Since the machines would

understand each other, and each machine would understand its "master", you could theorize that the conversations would occur smoothly.

As for the problems we mentioned earlier, about processing power and storage space – well that's what the cloud would provide for us. Our very own Cumulo-Indus could also provide a basis for the required connectivity and processing.

Must-clicks

<http://bit.ly/bfni4> | <http://bit.ly/bjCG7j> | <http://bit.ly/GwIzl> | <http://bit.ly/d12UJO> | <http://bit.ly/4CaDxs>



The Babel fish knows all